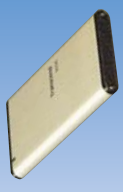
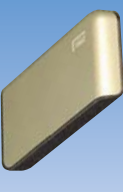


Seagate Portable Hard Drive	Transcend StoreJet 40 GB	Transcend StoreJet 2.5 80 GB	Western Digital Passport 120 GB
18.10	23.08	24.21	21.33
40	40	80	120
5400	4200	5400	5400
5.6	7.14	4.2	5.5
2	2	2	2
✓/✗	✓/✗	✓/✗	✓/✗
SeaTools Online, drivers and manuals	Storejet Software Utility, drivers for Windows 98SE, user manual	Storejet Software Utility, drivers for Windows 98SE, user manual	WD Sync on the hard drive
✗	✓	✓	✗
127 x 94 x 25	95 x 72 x 15	129 x 80 x 13	142 x 88 x 19
0.29	0.13	0.14	0.28
USB cable with two port connectors	USB data cable	USB power cable, USB data cable	USB data cable, power connector
✗	✗	✗	✗
4.5	3.75	3.5	4.25
23.21	18.87	24.13	28.18
9	5	6	5
17.5	18.5	17.8	18.5
25.6	16.9	24.5	28.7
23.8	16.6	24.8	25.5
24	18	21	27
29	20	22	32
19	15	18	22
22	18	26	26
20	14	21	21
19	14	10	15
69	74	55	57
51	61	50	43
168	186	148	112
46	65	42	44
39	55	48	36
196	185	154	101
177	195	152	116
1	2	2	1
0.14	0.23	0.10	0.09
16.16	10.00	11.88	8.64
5,880	9,500	8,000	11,000
57.46	51.95	60.22	58.15
			
+ Inexpensive, rugged build quality - Not a good software bundle	+ Good bundled software - Average build quality	+ Good performance and bundled software - Average build quality	+ Very good performance - Somewhat expensive

We then transferred files within the drives: this tests the capability of the drives' cache and its overall read and write speed. In the assorted file transfer, the Freecom FHD-2 PRO performed very well, taking just 89 seconds to copy the files within the drive. Its little brother, the FHD-XS, was the slowest at 390 seconds. The picture was no different in the sequential file copy test: the Freecom FHD-2 PRO again scored the highest at just 83 seconds, while the FHD-XS was again the slowest at 340 seconds.

The last real-world test we conducted was the multi-tasking test: here, we transferred 1 GB of assorted files to and from the external drives at the same time. This puts a strain on the interface and every other aspect of the drive. This time, yet again, the Freecom FHD-2 PRO was the fastest at 98 seconds, but was very closely followed by the Iomega at 102 seconds. The slowest drive was the Freecom FHD-XS—for the third time in a row—with a timing of 365 seconds.

Our Conclusion

As always, we factored in price along with the features and performance scores to decide on the winner.

The WD Passport has the lowest cost per MB at 9 paise, while the Freecom FHD-XS, which is priced very high (Rs 16,500) has the highest cost per MB of 40 paise. This high cost is, however, understandable because of the expensive bundled Acronis True Image software, as well as the build quality and finish.

We concluded that the LaCie Design by F. A. Porsche 40 GB should receive the Digit Best Buy Gold award, because of its astoundingly low price of Rs 5,250, as well as good build quality and sound performance.

The Transcend StoreJet 2.5 80 GB is priced at Rs 8,000—nice for an 80 GB external hard drive. We adjudged this one the winner of the Digit Best Buy Silver because of its above-average performance and its uniquely versatile software suite.

DESKTOP REPLACEMENT / BACKUP DRIVES

The specialty of the external hard drives comprising this segment is that they are meant to be used for frequent and large backups. Thus the drives under this category are larger than 120 GB, which is necessary for the scenarios they will be employed in.

These are priced considerably higher than those in the preceding category, and are accompanied by good data backup software. Most also have the FireWire interface, and some are even physically designed so they can be stacked one over the other when there's a need to augment data storage capacity.

A typical user of this kind of external hard drive is a system administrator who needs to frequently back up and restore data, while also moving data between computers not connected via a network.

We received five products in this category, which was dominated by the three drives sent in by Seagate—the Seagate Pushbutton Backup drives of 160, 200 and 400 GB. The others were